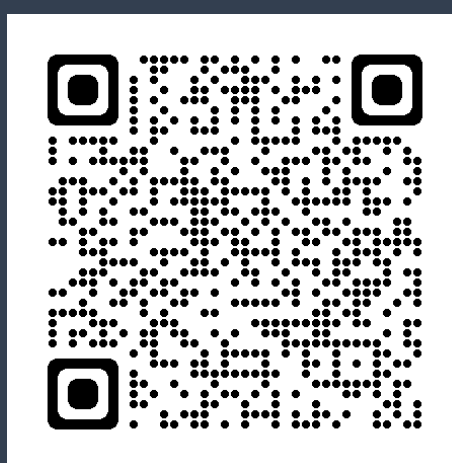


Time-Based Work-School Conflict is a Significant Predictor of Self-Perceived Stress in Hispanic College Students



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Methods

484 undergraduates ($M_{age} = 20.51$, $SD = 4.18$) completed an online survey. The sample was predominantly female (63.0%) and Hispanic (94.7%). Measures included:

- 6-item **Work-School Conflict** Scale (containing time- and strain-based items)
- 5-item **Perceived Work Demand** scale
- 10-item **Perceived Stress** Scale

Additionally, students reported **hours worked per week** and “**work inconsistency**” (10-point Likert-type scale, 1 = “not at all consistent”, 10 = “completely consistent”).

Statistical analyses were conducted using SPSS Version 28 and Hayes PROCESS.

Discussion

Our study adds to the limited research on stress in working college students. Employed students reported higher stress than their non-working peers, aligning with previous findings. Examination of work-related factors indicated that time-based work-school conflict was the only significant predictor, suggesting the conflicting time demands of work and school-related activities (e.g., doing homework, attending classes) results in increased stress.

Importantly, hours worked per week was not a significant predictor of stress in and of itself. Additionally, the strength of the relationship between time-based work-school conflict and stress differed based on whether students worked <20 or 20+ hrs/wk, with a *stronger* relationship in those working fewer than 20 hrs/wk. Possible explanations include stronger time-management skills or coping strategies to address ongoing work-school demands, or simply adapted to the higher level of time demands, reducing their overall perceptions of stress in those working more hours.

Our study benefits from obtaining data on an underrepresented population of (predominantly) Hispanic students, but this also limits the generalizability of the findings. Our study also relied on self-report which may introduce inaccuracy or bias and was based on cross-sectional data that limits cause-and-effect interpretations. Future research would benefit from careful consideration of socioeconomic status and examination of motivations for working (e.g., to satisfy needs vs. wants).

Introduction

Many college students manage multiple demanding responsibilities, frequently balancing academic obligations with part-time or full-time employment. Dual responsibilities can lead to feelings of stress, overload, and worry (Goldman & Wong, 1997; Garg, 1992; Wang et al., 2023), which may be amplified for those with irregular work patterns.

The current study examined work-related predictors of psychological stress in undergraduates. Specifically, we hypothesized that working college students would experience more stress than their non-working counterparts. We also explored which work-related factors (the amount of time worked, work demand, work-school conflict, and schedule inconsistency) would emerge as significant predictors of psychological stress.

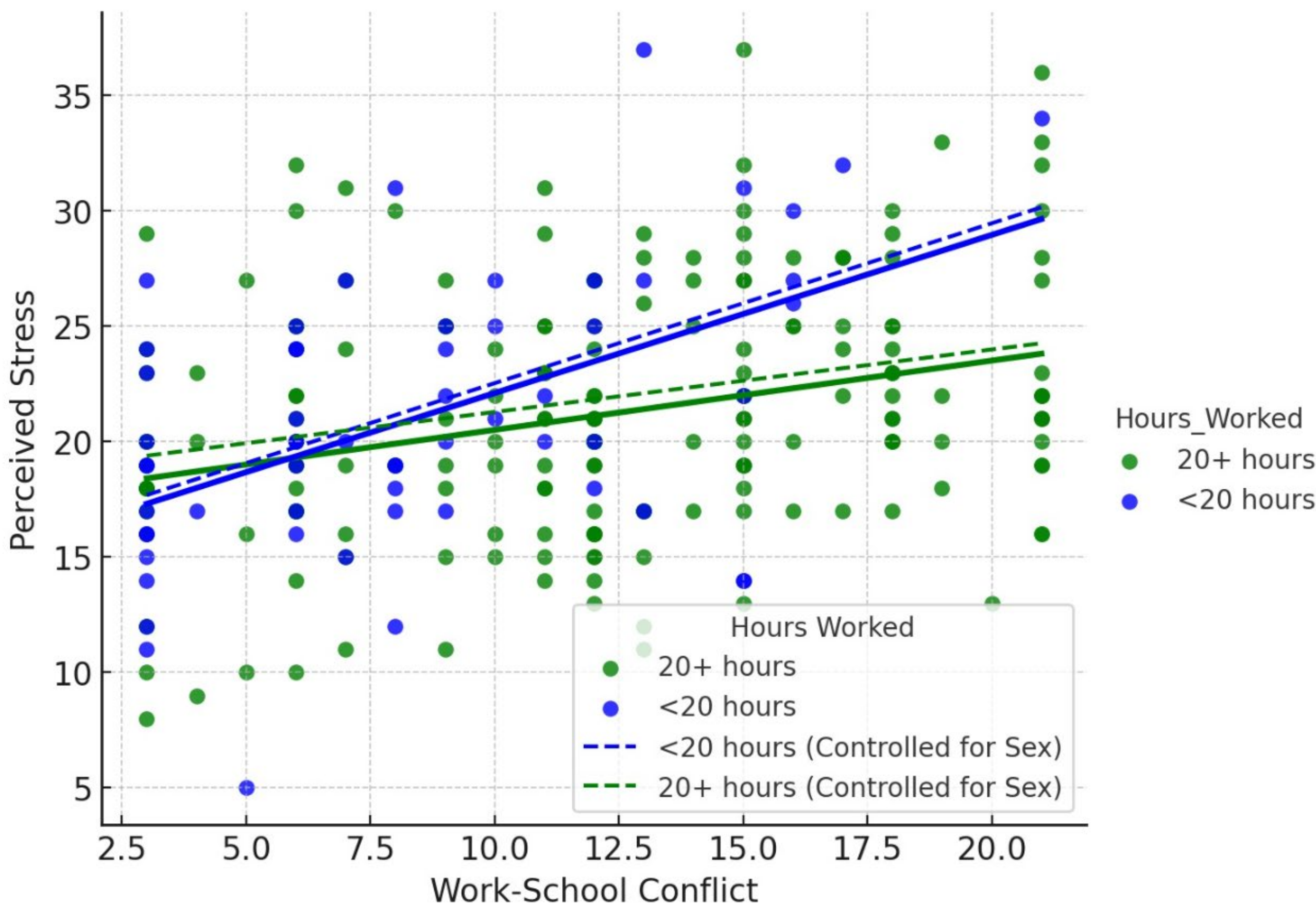
Results

Total Sample

Employed students (51.2% of sample) reported statistically significantly higher stress ($M = 21.15$, $SD = 5.56$) than students who were not employed; ($M = 19.92$, $SD = 5.96$), $t(459) = 2.30$, $p = .022$, 95% CI [0.18, 2.29]. The effect size was small (Cohen's $d=0.21$), indicating a modest difference in stress levels between the groups.

Employed Students

Females reported significantly higher stress ($M = 21.91$, $SD = 5.70$) than males ($M = 19.96$, $SD = 5.14$), $t(246) = -2.72$, $p = .007$.



A hierarchical regression analysis was conducted, controlling for sex. In Step 1, sex significantly predicted stress, $F(1,243) = 7.103$, $p = .008$, explaining 2.8% of variance. In Step 2, adding work-related variables explained an additional 11.4% of variance, $F(5,238) = 6.341$, $p < .001$. Among work-related predictors, time-based work-school conflict was the only significant predictor, $\beta = .220$, $p = .018$.

Additionally, the strength of the relationship between work-school conflict and stress was moderated by weekly work hours (<20 vs. 20+ hrs/wk), $F(4, 242) = 11.08$, $p < .001$, explaining 15.5% of the variance in stress. Hours worked per week (dichotomous) was not a significant predictor of perceived stress, $B = 2.78$, $SE = 1.74$, $t(242) = 1.60$, $p = .11$. However, both time-based work-school conflict and sex were significant predictors ($B = 1.12$, $SE = 0.31$, $t(242) = 3.62$, $p < .001$ and $B = 1.65$, $SE = 0.69$, $t(242) = 2.41$, $p = .017$, respectively). The interaction between work-school conflict and hours worked was statistically significant, $B = -0.42$, $SE = 0.17$, $t(242) = -2.53$, $p = .012$. Specifically, controlling for sex, the relationship between work-school conflict and perceived stress was *stronger* at *lower* levels of hours worked per week.